Comprehensive Tangkhul Naga Grammar

Phonology, Morphology, Case Systems, Verb Conjugations & Syntax

Tangkhul Language Library Digital Archive -- Exhaustive Canonical Edition

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CHAPTER 1: PHONOLOGY, ORTHOGRAPHY & ALPHABET

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Tangkhul Roman Alphabet & Vowel System

Tangkhul utilizes a Latin-based phonetic alphabet introduced by Rev. William Pettigrew in 1897 and standardized by the Tangkhul Literature Society (TLS). Vo

Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Long vowels marked with macrons (?, ?, ?, ?, ?) distinguish lexical minimal pairs (e.g., 'ram' [country] vs 'r?m' [dry field]).
* Diphthongs include: ei (meira), ai (kakhai), ao (vanao), ui (ngashui), oi (choi).

Consonant Inventory

Stops: p, t, k, ph, th, kh, b, d, g. Nasals: m, n, ng. Fricatives: s, sh, h, z. Liquids: r, l. Glides: w, y.

Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Velar nasal 'ng' can occur in syllable initial, medial, and coda positions (e.g., ngalei [earth], thingrong [tree]).
* Initial consonant clusters predominantly involve liquids: pr-, tr-, kr-, phr-, thr-, khr-.

CHAPTER 2: NOUN MORPHOLOGY & GENDER SYSTEM

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Gender Classification

Tangkhul distinguishes biological and social gender through suffixed markers.
Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Human Masculine: -mayar / -va (e.g., ngalava -> youth/man, naomayar -> boy/son).
* Human Feminine: -shanao / -la (e.g., shanaonao -> girl/daughter, ava -> mother).
* Animal Gender: Male suffix -khon / -mayara (simuk-mayara [bull]), Female suffix -lui / -shanao (simuk-lui [cow]).

Number & Pluralization

Plurality is marked by appending collective and pluralizing postpositions.
Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Plural suffix -bing / -bina: mi (person) -> mibing (people), vanao (bird) -> vanaobing (birds).
* Collective marker -saikora (all/entirety): ngalanaobing saikora (all the young maidens).

CHAPTER 3: CASE MARKING SYSTEM (POSTPOSITIONS)

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Core Case Postpositions

Tangkhul is an agglutinative postpositional language. Cases are attached directly to the noun phrase head.

Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Nominative / Agentive: -na (e.g., I-na shansera -> I have read).
* Accusative / Dative: -li (e.g., Ali milu -> Give to him; Vanaoli thei -> Saw the bird).
* Instrumental: -eina (e.g., Ngaphei-eina tulu -> Cut with a machete).
* Genitive / Possessive: -wui (e.g., Shim-wui kuiphung -> The pillar of the house).
* Locative: -li (e.g., Kaphung-li pamda -> Residing on the mountain).
* Ablative: -wui eina / -li eina (e.g., Ukhrul-wui eina kazat -> Coming from Ukhrul).
* Comitative / Associative: -le / -nga (e.g., Amei-le kazat -> Walking together with brother).

CHAPTER 4: PRONOUN PARADIGMS & DECLENSIONS

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Personal Pronouns

First, second, and third person pronouns with singular, dual, and plural distinctions.
Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* 1st Person Singular: I (I, me) | Plural: Ithum (we, us) | Dual: Inikha (the two of us).
* 2nd Person Singular: Na (you) | Plural: Nathum (you all) | Dual: Nanikha (the two of you).
* 3rd Person Singular: Ana (he/she/it) | Plural: Amathum (they, them).
* Demonstratives: Hi (this), Chi (that), Hili (here), Chili (there).

CHAPTER 5: ADJECTIVES, NUMERALS & CLASSIFIERS

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Adjective Formation & Comparison

Most Tangkhul adjectives are derived from stative verbal roots prefixed with ka- or kha-.
Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Positive: kapha (good), kakhangar (heavy), kathuk (deep), kahung (red).
* Comparative suffix: -shang / -meila (kapha-meila -> better than).
* Superlative suffix: -saikora wui meila / -tak (kaphatak -> the very best).

Cardinal Numerals

1: akha, 2: khani, 3: kathum, 4: mati, 5: phanga, 6: taruk, 7: shini, 8: shet, 9: chiko, 10: thara, 20: maku, 100: sha akha.
Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Numerals follow the noun they qualify: mi kathum (three persons), thingrong mati (four trees).

CHAPTER 6: VERB MORPHOLOGY, ASPECT & TENSE

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Tense and Aspect Suffixes

Tangkhul verbs carry inflectional suffixes indicating tense, aspect, and completion.

Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Root verbs take prefix ka- / kha- in citation/infinitive form: kasa (to do), kazat (to go), kapam (to sit).
* Present Simple / Habitual: -i / -ya (e.g., I zat-ya -> I go).
* Present Continuous: -da lei (e.g., I pam-da lei -> I am sitting / waiting).
* Past Perfective: -ser-re / -haowa (e.g., Ana zat-haowa -> He has departed).
* Future Tense: -ra (e.g., Ithum shok-ra -> We will come out / emerge).
* Imperative: -lu (positive: Salu -> Do it!), -kha (negative: Masalu -> Don’t do it!).

CHAPTER 7: NEGATION, INTERROGATION & MODALITY

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Negative Particles

Negation in Tangkhul is achieved primarily through the circumfix ma-...-mana.

Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Declarative Negation: ma- [verb root] -mana (e.g., I ma-thei-mana -> I do not see/know).
* Stative Negation: ma-kalei (is not / does not exist) vs lei (exists).
* Prohibitive Imperative: ma- [verb root] -alu (e.g., Ma-zat-alu -> Do not go!).

Interrogative Particles

Questions end with interrogative enclitics.

Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Polar (Yes/No) questions: -la? (e.g., Na pamra-la? -> Will you stay?).
* Wh-Questions: Khi (what), Kachida (where), Khipa (who), Khitharan (when), Khipakha (why).

CHAPTER 8: SYNTAX, WORD ORDER & DISCOURSE PARTICLES

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Basic Constituent Order (SOV)

Tangkhul strictly adheres to Subject-Object-Verb (SOV) typology with head-final syntactic trees.

Linguistic Rules & Examples:

* Standard word order: Subject + Object + Verb (e.g., Mayarnao-na [S] kharai [O] phungda lei [V] -> The man is carrying the basket).
* Modifier precedes or follows based on category: Demonstratives precede, numerals and adjectives follow head nouns.
* Honorific and polite particles: -sho, -rei, -meo signify mutual respect between kin and elders.